

Passages - Heretics

Everything matters - except everything

But there are some people, nevertheless - and I am one of them - who think that the most practical and important thing about a man is still his view of the universe.

Every one of the popular modern phrases and ideals is a dodge in order to shirk the problem of what is good.

We are fond of talking about "liberty;" that, as we talk of it, is a dodge to avoid discussing what is good. We are fond of talking about "progress;" that is a dodge to avoid discussing what is good. We are fond of talking about "education;" that is a dodge to avoid discussing what is good.

Nobody can be progressive without being doctrinal; I might almost say that nobody can be progressive without being infallible. For progress by its very name indicates a direction; and the moment we are in the least doubtful about the direction, we become in the same degree doubtful about the progress.

There is no such thing on earth as an uninteresting subject; the only thing that can exist is an uninterested person.

for we admire things with reasons, but love them without reasons

That light melancholy with which a man looks back on having been the citizen of many communities, of that light melancholy with which a man looks back on having been the lover of many women. He is the philanderer of the nations. But a

man may have learnt much about women in flirtations, and still be ignorant of first love; a man may have known as many lands as Ulysses, and still be ignorant of patriotism.

"Blessed is he that expecteth nothing, for he shall be gloriously surprised."

Little things please great minds

Humility is so practical a virtue that men think it must be a vice. Humility is so successful that it is mistaken for pride.

Whenever there was in them the least touch of pride in what they had done, there was a good ground for attacking them; but so long as they were wholly humble, they were wholly victorious.

Adventures are to those to whom they are most unexpected - that is, most romantic. Adventures are to the shy: in this sense adventures are to the unadventurous.

Health has to do with carelessness

a permanent possibility of selfishness arises from the mere fact of having a self, and not from any accidents of education or ill-treatment. And the weakness of all Utopias is this, that they take the greatest difficulty of man and assume it to be overcome, and then give an elaborate account of the overcoming of the smaller ones.

Supermen, if not good men, are vermin.

Only the weak can be brave; and yet again, in practice, only those who can be brave can be trusted, in time of doubt, to be strong.

A great man is not a man so strong that he feels less than other men; he is a man so strong that he feels more. Sensibility is the definition of life.

Vulgarity there always was wherever there was joy, wherever there was faith in the gods. Wherever you have belief you will have hilarity, wherever you have hilarity you will have some dangers. And as creed and mythology produce this gross and vigorous life, so in its turn this gross and vigorous life will always produce creed and mythology. The absence from modern life of both the higher and lower forms of faith is largely due to a divorce from nature and the trees and clouds.

It is easy to deny one's self festivity; it is difficult to deny one's self normality.

The one genuinely dangerous and immoral way of drinking wine is to drink it as a medicine.

Never drink because you need it, for this is rational drinking, and the way to death and hell. But drink because you do not need it, for this is irrational drinking, and the ancient health of the world.

Walter Pater said that we were all under sentence of death, and the only course was to enjoy exquisite moments simply for those moments' sake. The same lesson was taught by the very powerful and very desolate philosophy of Oscar Wilde. It is the carpe diem religion; but the carpe diem religion is not the religion of happy people, but of very unhappy people.

Great joy does not gather the rosebuds while it may; its eyes are fixed on the

immortal rose which Dante saw. in this cult of the pessimistic pleasure-seeker the *Rubáiyat* stands first in our time; but it does not stand alone. Many of the most brilliant intellects of our time have urged us to the same self-conscious snatching at a rare delight. Great joy has in it the sense of immortality; the very splendour of youth is the sense that it has all space to stretch its legs in. In all great comic literature, in "Tristram Shandy" or "Pickwick," there is this sense of space and incorruptibility; we feel the characters are deathless people in an endless tale

To do this is to rationalize the happiness, and therefore to destroy it.

the lover thinks of his love as something that cannot end.

These moments are filled with eternity; these moments are joyful because they do not seem momentary

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It is not only true that humility is a much wiser and more vigorous thing than pride. It is also true that vanity is a much wiser and more vigorous thing than pride. Vanity is social - it is almost a kind of comradeship; pride is solitary and uncivilized. Vanity is active; it desires the applause of infinite multitudes; pride is passive, desiring only the applause of one person, which it already has.

A man who thinks a great deal about himself will try to be many-sided, attempt a theatrical excellence at all points, will try to be an encyclopedia of culture, and his own real personality will be lost in that false universalism.

Thinking about himself will lead to trying to

be the universe; trying to be the universe will lead to ceasing to be anything.

It is necessary to cease to be a man in order to do justice to a microbe; it is not necessary to cease to be a man in order to do justice to men.

We do not understand the savage for the same reason that the savage does not understand himself.

When a tree really looks like a man our knees knock under us. And when the whole universe looks like a man we fall on our faces.

Exactly at the instant when hope ceases to be reasonable it begins to be useful.

Romance consists in thinking a thing more delightful because it is dangerous.

The ultimate psychological truth is not that no man is a hero to his valet.

The ultimate psychological truth, the foundation of Christianity, is that no man is a hero to himself.

Carlyle said that men were mostly fools. Christianity, with a surer and more reverent realism, says that they are all fools. This doctrine is sometimes called the doctrine of original sin. It may also be described as the doctrine of the equality of men.

Nationality exists, and has nothing in the world to do with race. Nationality is a product of the human soul and will; it is a spiritual product.

What we dread about our neighbours, in short, is not the narrowness of their horizon, but their superb tendency to

broaden it. The misanthropes pretend that they despise humanity for its weakness. As a matter of fact, they hate it for its strength.

Every man has hated mankind when he was less than a man.

Life is not a thing from outside, but a thing from inside. Above all, they all insist upon the fact that life, if it be a truly stimulating and fascinating life, is a thing which, of its nature, exists in spite of ourselves.

Those who wish, rightly or wrongly, to step out of the institution of family, do definitely wish to step into a narrower world. They are dismayed and terrified by the largeness and variety of the family.

The supreme adventure is being born

The reason why the lives of the rich are at bottom so tame and uneventful is simply that they can choose the events. They are dull because they are omnipotent. They fail to feel adventures because they can make the adventures. The thing which keeps life romantic and full of fiery possibilities is the existence of these great plain limitations which force all of us to meet the things we do not like or do not expect.

They say they wish to be as strong as the universe, but they really wish the whole universe as weak as themselves.

The oligarchic character of the modern English commonwealth does not rest, like many oligarchies, on the cruelty of the rich to the poor. It does not even rest on the kindness of the rich to the poor. It rests on the perennial and unfailing kindness of the poor to the rich.

Out of the emptiness of the heart the mouth speaketh.

To take a thing and make a joke out of it is not to take it in vain. It is, on the contrary, to take it and use it for an uncommonly good object.

Funny is the opposite of not funny, and of nothing else.

The thing which is fundamentally and really frivolous is not a careless joke. The thing which is fundamentally and really frivolous is a careless solemnity.

Unless a man is in part a humorist, he is only in part a man.

The great tragedy of the artistic temperament is that it cannot produce any art.

We find that while there is a perfectly genuine danger of fanaticism from the men who have unworldly ideals, the permanent and urgent danger of fanaticism is from the men who have worldly ideals.

A small artist is content with art; a great artist is content with nothing except everything.

In real life the people who are most bigoted are the people who have no convictions at all.

Ideas are dangerous, but the man to whom they are least dangerous is the man of ideas. He is acquainted with ideas, and moves among them like a lion-tamer. Ideas are dangerous, but the man to whom they are most dangerous is the man of no ideas.

The man of no ideas will find the first idea fly to his head like wine to the head of a teetotaller.